

# Architecture as Ideas

*Six buildings, each making a different claim about what a building is for.*

## 1. The Parthenon

*447–432 BCE · Pentelic marble · The Acropolis, Athens*

The Parthenon was built as a temple to Athena at the height of Athenian power. Its reputation rests on proportion: its parts were tuned to a system of ratios meant to express order itself. The columns swell slightly and lean inward, and the platform curves upward at its centre, so almost nothing in it is truly straight. These refinements correct the eye, and a building full of subtle curves reads as perfectly regular. Its claim is that beauty is mathematical, a harmony the mind recognises even when the eye cannot name it.

*Well building hath three conditions: firmness, commodity, and delight. — Vitruvius, rendered by Sir Henry Wotton (1624)*

*They were created in a short time for all time; for in beauty each of them was, even at that time, ancient, but in the freshness of its vigour it is, even to the present day, recent and newly made. — Plutarch, Life of Pericles*

## 2. Chartres Cathedral

*c. 1194–1220 · Limestone and stained glass · Chartres, France*

When the earlier cathedral burned in 1194, Chartres was rebuilt within a single generation, which gives it an unusual unity. Gothic structure, the pointed arch, the rib vault and the flying buttress, carried the weight of the roof on a skeleton of stone, so the walls no longer had to hold the building up. Freed of that task, they could be opened into vast windows. Chartres keeps most of its medieval glass, so the interior is washed in coloured light. For its builders this was theology, not decoration: light standing for the divine, the building a model of heaven on earth.

*The dull mind rises to truth through that which is material. — Abbot Suger, On the Abbey Church of St-Denis (12th century)*

*No good work whatever can be perfect, and the demand for perfection is always a sign of a misunderstanding of the ends of art. — John Ruskin, The Stones of Venice (1853)*

## 3. The Sagrada Família

*1882–2026 · Stone · Antoni Gaudí · Barcelona*

Gaudí took charge of the Sagrada Família in 1883 and worked on it until his death in 1926, when he was struck by a tram. He left it far from finished, and it has been built ever since from his models; the central tower was completed in February 2026, near the centenary of his death, making it the tallest church in the world.

Gaudí designed by studying nature rather than older buildings. His columns branch like trees to hold the roof, and he found his structures by hanging weighted strings to see which shapes stand up on their own. The building argues that the deepest source for architecture is the natural world, and behind it, for Gaudí, its creator.

*Originality consists in returning to the origin.* — Antoni Gaudí

*Those who look for the laws of nature as a support for their new works collaborate with the creator.* — Antoni Gaudí

## 4. Casa Batlló

1904–1906 · Remodelled apartment building · Antoni Gaudí · Barcelona

Casa Batlló is a remodelling: Gaudí took an ordinary apartment block and reworked its façade and interior into something that looks grown rather than built. The front has no straight lines. The balconies resemble bone or mask, the pillars look like limbs, the roof curves like an animal's back, and the surface is covered in broken tiles that shift colour as the light moves. Locals call it the “house of bones.” Where the Sagrada Família turns nature into structure, Casa Batlló turns it into surface, treating a home as a living body rather than a container.

*The straight line belongs to men, the curved line to God.* — Antoni Gaudí

*There are no straight lines or sharp corners in nature. Therefore, buildings must have no straight lines or sharp corners.* — Antoni Gaudí

## 5. Haus Wittgenstein

1926–1928 · Ludwig Wittgenstein with Paul Engelmann · Vienna

The philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein designed this house for his sister, with the architect Paul Engelmann. He had no training, but gave it the same exactness he brought to philosophy. There is no ornament, no carpet or curtain; the proportions of the rooms were calculated precisely, and he designed the door handles, window catches and radiators himself. Near the end he had a ceiling raised by three centimetres to settle a room's proportions. The house tests an idea: that a building, like a sentence, can be stripped to exactly what it needs and no more. His sister admired it and admitted she could not imagine living in it.

*Architecture is a gesture. Not every purposive movement of the human body is a gesture, and no more is every building designed for a purpose architecture.* — Ludwig Wittgenstein, Culture and Value

*The evolution of culture marches with the elimination of ornament from useful objects.* — Adolf Loos, Ornament and Crime (1908)

## 6. The Barbican Estate

1965–1976 · Reinforced concrete · Chamberlin, Powell and Bon · City of London

The Barbican is a housing estate and arts centre built on a part of London flattened by bombing in the war. It is the best-known British example of Brutalism, a name from *béton brut*, French for raw concrete. Its surfaces were left rough and hammered by hand to expose the granite aggregate, and its towers and walkways were planned as a complete city in miniature, lifting people above the street. Brutalism carried a moral claim: that a building should show honestly what it is made of and how it was made. Much of the public has always found it ugly, which makes it a useful case for asking whether ugliness is a fair charge against a building or beside the point.

*Brutalism tries to face up to a mass-production society, and drag a rough poetry out of the confused and powerful forces which are at work.* — Reyner Banham, *The New Brutalism* (1955)

*A monstrous carbuncle on the face of a much-loved and elegant friend.* — Charles, then Prince of Wales, attacking a proposed modern building (1984)